

Chapter 160-1

The wedding that seemed like a joke became a topic of conversation for the wealthy elites for a long time.

It wasn't as if this kind of thing—a younger sister substituting in marriage—had never happened before.

In arranged marriages, there was always bound to be someone who was disliked.

When the family patriarch particularly doted on a certain child, and the marriage partner wasn't valued, cases of pushing an unfavored daughter out as a substitute bride were everywhere. It wasn't big news.

But those were all done secretly.

The two families would discuss it, find some excuse to swap the marriage partner, and no one would know.

When people talked about it afterward, they would at most laugh a little. There wasn't much discussion value—it wasn't as interesting as chatting about entertainment industry gossip.

But the situation between Shen Fenghe and Gu Yixue was different.

Going to substitute at the wedding venue itself, especially when Gu Chunmian was still wearing a wedding dress and appeared on the red carpet, only to stand Shen Fenghe up right when they were about to get married.

Who didn't know that Shen Fenghe was famously capable and shrewd?

Shen Fenghe's father was named Shen Yaobo. Under his leadership, the Shen family rose to a higher level. The original Shen family actually couldn't compare to the Gu family—after all, the Gu family had a century-old foundation. They had successfully transformed from the heavy industry era, riding the tides of time with ancestral blessings protecting them.

The Shen family was slightly inferior.

But under Shen Yaobo's hands, the Shen family forcefully rose to equal status with the Gu family. It was from then that the phrase "Twin Heroes of Haizhou" came about.

When the family enterprise was passed down to Shen Fenghe, she managed to surpass the Gu family.

It had to be said that the younger generation of the Gu family was disappointing—not a single one could take on major responsibilities. The patriarch's most beloved grandchild was Gu Chunmian, but she was just a pretty face. As she grew older, she turned into a hopeless romantic¹. Once she turned twenty, she said she wanted to marry the one she loved and even eloped with her lover once.

And that so-called lover of hers had once taken ten million to break up with her.

Later, when that person fell on hard times, she returned to the country and came back to Gu Chunmian's side—and Gu Chunmian actually accepted her.

Gu Chunmian even got pregnant and brought her "true love" to the Gu family's door to force them into accepting the marriage, nearly making the old master of the Gu family faint from anger.

Even so, the Gu family still didn't give up on Gu Chunmian.

Abortion wasn't allowed domestically, so the Gu family took Gu Chunmian abroad to find a private doctor to terminate the pregnancy. Gu Chunmian caused quite a fuss over this, but she couldn't win against them.

The arm couldn't twist against the thigh².

She had to rely on the Gu family to be the Gu family's eldest daughter, to be Gu Chunmian.

If she left the Gu family, she didn't have a single survival skill—she would be nothing but a stray dog.

So over the years, the Gu family couldn't suppress her, and she couldn't persuade the Gu family.

They remained at this stalemate until now.

The Gu family had other direct descendants, and there were plenty waiting to inherit the family business, but they were all good-for-nothings with no promise.

One of them was even caught meeting up with a celebrity, then got blackmailed by the minor celebrity in a honey trap³.

At that time, it was Shen Fenghe who helped suppress the matter.

None of the younger generation of the Gu family could be presentable.

Oh, except for Gu Yixue.

But who would have thought that the only promising one among the Gu family's grandchildren was actually the Gu family's illegitimate daughter—Gu Yixue.

That ordinary Beta whose mother, when she was dying, brought her to kneel outside the Gu family's main gate for two days and two nights, got drenched in rain for two nights, and nearly died from a high fever.

Because of evolutionary differences, Betas couldn't smell Alpha and Omega pheromones and weren't affected by them. Correspondingly, their physical constitution was generally not as good as Alphas and Omegas.

In this world, most geniuses were Alphas or Omegas.

But as it happened, Gu Yixue was just a Beta.

An ordinary Beta.

However, Gu Yixue's appearance and intelligence both met the standards of an Alpha or Omega.

That little girl who nearly died in the rainy night and through countless humiliations went abroad at sixteen and eventually amazed the entire world under the name "Quella."

She was a Chinese person who made a name for herself in a place teeming with foreigners.

The achievements she obtained moved the entire entertainment industry.

Even though these elite circles looked down on the entertainment industry, they were all aware of the developments within it.

So at that time, many people said that the Gu family might look upon Gu Yixue more favorably.

But unexpectedly, Gu Yixue remained the most marginalized person in the Gu family.

The Gu family still stubbornly tried to save that hopeless case⁴.

Because Gu Chunmian was the legitimate one.

Gu Yixue was just an illegitimate daughter—lowly and cheap.

These were the words Gu's father had used to curse Gu Yixue's mother, which were overheard by someone with ulterior motives and spread around, causing quite a controversy.

Gu Yixue never cared.

Since she dared to walk through that door wearing a wedding dress, she had prepared for everything.

Even if there was a cliff ahead, she could stride forward without hesitation.

How many times can a person be brave for themselves?

Perhaps only once.

At that day's wedding banquet, hardly anyone could eat. Only Gu Yixue and Shen Fenghe, the two parties involved, ate their fill as if nothing had happened.

Liang Shi followed beside Gu Yixue and barely managed to get a meal, but everyone around her wasn't touching their chopsticks much, so she felt too embarrassed to eat either.

Halfway through the meal, Shen Hui came over to find her, asking what exactly was going on. Why did Gu Yixue come to crash the wedding?

Liang Shi was stunned, then said hesitantly: "This is probably called... filling in?"

Shen Hui: "....."

What the hell, filling in.

"Why are you with her?" Shen Hui asked. "In other words, why would you become her accomplice?"

Liang Shi: ".....She's my friend."

"Fine," Shen Hui said. "That's quite....."

Before she could finish her assessment, a crisp voice called out from behind: "Miss Liang, Ah Hui."

Liang Shi looked up—it was the aunt who had been sitting at the main table earlier, and also the aunt she had encountered at the museum restroom entrance that day. If she remembered correctly, her name should be Zhu Mingqi?

Liang Shi roughly understood now—this was Shen Hui's mother.

It was quite a coincidence, when you thought about it.

She had met the members of the Shen family at different times.

First Shen Hui, then Shen Siyan, then Shen Fenghe, then Zhu Mingqi. Aside from Mr. Shen, she had gathered the complete set of the Shen family.

Footnotes:

¹ **Hopeless romantic (戀愛腦)**: Literally "romance brain" - a Chinese internet slang term describing someone who prioritizes romantic love above all else, often making irrational decisions for the sake of love.

² **The arm couldn't twist against the thigh (胳膊擰不過大腿)**: A Chinese idiom meaning the weak cannot prevail against the strong; one cannot fight against those more powerful than oneself.

³ **Honey trap (仙人跳)**: Literally "immortal jump" - a type of scam/blackmail scheme in Chinese, typically where someone is lured into a compromising situation (usually romantic or sexual) and then extorted.

⁴ **Hopeless case (扶不起來的阿鬥)**: A Chinese idiom referring to Liu Shan (nicknamed "A Dou"), the incompetent son of Liu Bei from the Three Kingdoms period. The phrase describes someone who cannot be helped no matter how much support they receive—a lost cause.